

SMOKE AND ASHES
A Writer's Journey through Opium's Hidden Histories
By Amitav Ghosh
HARPERCOLLINS
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trade—the original funky town. As he untangles the narrative strands that come together in this picture, we see the knots of causality emerge. Most postcolonial scholars know about the three-way trade in opium and tea between Britain, India and China, but the extent to which the US played a role in this trade, and how foundational those opium profits were to many reputed US corporations and business houses existing today, is not so well-publicised.

With slavery, opium is the other vice-trade that built the US, and Ghosh's story shows us that those habits have not been forgotten by corporate America. Ghosh's narrative leads us to Purdue Pharma, the Sacklers (and their China connection) and the current opiate crisis. "Opiates are one of the leading causes of death right now, but with a crisis of this kind, it's very easy to ignore," says Ghosh. "It happens silently, in people's homes...but it's one of the worst crises America has faced. Pakistan too. They're coming unstuck because of the influx of cheap opiates."

I asked Ghosh why a section of the rich are pushing the opiate agenda. He was silent for a moment, then he said, "They talk of a Malthusian solution." These words chilled me. The current craze for AI (which is actually not AI) is part of that solution: now that the masters have machines, the poor are not to be cultivated, they are to be superseded.

This represents a change in US strategy from the so-called 'War on Drugs' of the Eighties and Nineties, which was a flimsy excuse for parents to harass children, cops to put more people of non-white ancestry in jail, and intelligence agencies to destabilise governments. Yet, the same Republicans who backed Nancy Reagan's Just Say No campaign are now making excuses to keep the Sacklers out of jail, pooh-poohing the scandal and blaming the victims. Opium does indeed have magical powers.

In the last section of the book, Ghosh says that India is yet to reckon with its role in the opium trade, and has dismissed its involvement from the collective memory. We may have been unwilling partners and participants, but that does not negate the fact that we did participate. Our own problematic relationship with drugs and drug use, far too complex to even outline here, is a legacy of the clash and synergy between indigenous cultures of usage and colonial extractionism.

Smoke and Ashes is a must-read for those who wish to understand the conflagration of our world. In it, Ghosh continues the dissection of modern society that he frames in *The Great Derangement* (2016). These books lay bare the methods and morals of those who have the means to impose their will on us, and they demand of us the courage to face the consequences of that imposition. ■

Rimi B. Chatterjee



THE DARK TRUTH (clockwise from above) Pictures from Arko Datto's Kings of a Bereft Land; Where Do We Go When the Final Wave Hits; Terra Mutata

Datto has a compelling shot of street vendors who had set up shop on a day in Delhi when pollution levels were hazardous to human health. The frame is drenched in the otherworldly aura of LED lamps. For the *Shunyo Raja (King of A Bereft Land)* monographies on the battered Sundarbans and its denizens, Datto, through the extensive use of the flash and infra-red imagery, conjured up the terror of the night and the dark waters. India is already at the receiving end of extreme climate change events like floods, droughts and heatwaves. In light of this, Datto's work takes on an air of urgency. ■

Soumitra Das

Datto has two exhibitions on currently: *Shunyo Raja (King of a Bereft Land)* at the Kathleen O. Ellis Gallery & Hallway Gallery, Syracuse, USA (till August 4) and *Where Do We Go When the Final Wave Hits* at Artlab Eyeland festival in Taranto, Italy (till July 31)